

Current business affairs

Topic : SAARC

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SAARC :

SAARC stands for the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation. It is an intergovernmental organization comprising eight member countries in South Asia. SAARC was established in 1985 with the aim of promoting regional cooperation and integration among its member nations. The organization focuses on various areas of cooperation, including economic, social, cultural, and technical fields. SAARC holds regular summits where leaders from member countries discuss and collaborate on issues of mutual interest, such as trade, poverty alleviation, climate change, and regional security.

SAARC history and Introduction :

- The South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC) is an intergovernmental organization that was established on December 8, 1985, with the signing of the SAARC Charter by the heads of state or government of seven South Asian countries: Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, Maldives, Nepal, Pakistan, and Sri Lanka. Afghanistan joined as a member in 2007, making it a total of eight member countries.
- The idea of regional cooperation in South Asia was first proposed by Bangladesh's President Ziaur Rahman in 1980. The objective was to promote peace, stability, and economic development in the region through increased cooperation and understanding among member countries.
- SAARC's primary goal is to foster regional integration and cooperation in various areas, including trade, economy, agriculture, culture, science and technology, and social development. It aims to improve the living standards of people in the region and promote mutual trust and understanding among member nations.
- Over the years, SAARC has held numerous summits where leaders from member countries gather to discuss and address regional issues. These summits provide a

platform for dialogue, cooperation, and the signing of agreements and declarations on various matters of mutual interest.

SAARC Countries: 🌸

During SAARC's foundation, seven SAARC countries are mainly located in South Asia, i.e. India, Pakistan, Bhutan, Nepal, Bangladesh, Maldives, and Sri Lanka. Afghanistan became its eighth member in April 2007 at the SAARC's 14th summit.

Observer SAARC Member Countries: 🌸

There are currently nine Observers of SAARC, namely:

- Australia
- China
- EU
- Japan
- Mauritius
- Iran
- Republic of Korea
- Myanmar
- The United States

SAARC Headquarters: 🌸

The SAARC's headquarters and secretariat are located in Kathmandu, Nepal. On December 8th, 1985, the SAARC Charter was signed in Dhaka and established it.

Objectives or functions of SAARC : 🌸

There are the following functions or objectives of SAARC :

Promote regional cooperation:

SAARC aims to enhance cooperation and collaboration among member countries in various areas, including economics, trade, agriculture, technology, culture, and social development. The organization seeks to foster mutual understanding and strengthen regional ties.

Foster social and cultural development:

SAARC aims to promote social progress and cultural development in the region. It encourages member countries to exchange experiences, knowledge, and best practices in areas such as education, health, poverty alleviation, and women's empowerment.

Strengthen regional security:

SAARC seeks to enhance regional security by promoting cooperation in combating terrorism, drug trafficking, and other transnational crimes. It encourages member countries to share intelligence, coordinate efforts, and develop joint strategies to address common security challenges.

Promote the welfare of peoples of South Asia and improve their quality of life :

SAARC Aims to help the people of South Asia and make their lives better. It brings together countries like India, Pakistan, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, Nepal, Bhutan, and the Maldives.

The main goal of SAARC is to promote the welfare of the people in this region. This means they want to improve the lives of individuals and make sure they have a good quality of life. They do this by working together on various issues that affect the people of South Asia.

Address common challenges:

SAARC provides a platform for member countries to discuss and address common challenges such as poverty, climate change, natural disasters, and food security.

Promote regional connectivity:

SAARC aims to enhance regional connectivity by improving transportation, communication, and energy infrastructure within the region.

Facilitate regional cooperation in agriculture :

SAARC promotes cooperation among member countries in the field of agriculture, including sharing best practices, technology transfer, and joint research and development.

Enhance cooperation in science and technology:

SAARC encourages cooperation among member countries in the field of science and technology, including joint research projects, exchange of scientists, and sharing of scientific knowledge.

Foster regional peace and stability:

SAARC aims to promote peace, stability, and security in the region. It encourages dialogue, cooperation, and confidence-building measures among member countries to resolve conflicts, prevent disputes, and maintain regional peace.

Principles of SAARC:

There are the following principles of SAARC:

Respect for sovereignty, territorial integrity, political equality, and independence of all member states:

SAARC emphasizes the importance of respecting the sovereignty and territorial integrity of each member state, ensuring political equality, and recognizing their independence.

Non-interference in the internal affairs of member states:

SAARC promotes non-interference in the internal affairs of member states, respecting their political systems, and refraining from any actions that may undermine their sovereignty.

Cooperation based on mutual benefit:

SAARC encourages cooperation among member states based on mutual benefit, recognizing that collaboration can lead to shared prosperity and development in the region.

Peaceful settlement of disputes:

SAARC advocates for the peaceful settlement of disputes among member states through dialogue, negotiation, and other peaceful means, in accordance with international law.

SAARC achievements

A Free Trade Area is established by the member countries to increase their internal trade and lessen the trade gap of some states considerably. SAARC is comparatively a new organization in the global arena.

SAARC Free Trade Agreement – SAFTA :

SAFTA was signed to reduce customs duties of all traded goods to zero by the year 2016. The agreement was confined to goods, but excluding all services like information technology.

South Asia Preferential Trading Agreement – SAPTA :

SAPTA for promoting trade amongst the member countries came into effect in 1995.

SAARC Agreement on Trade in Services – SATIS :

The SAARC Agreement on Trade in Services is an agreement between the member countries of the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC) to promote trade in services. It refers to the exchange of services between countries. Services can include things like banking, tourism, telecommunications, education, healthcare, and many others. It encourages countries to remove barriers and restrictions that may hinder the flow of services across borders.

SAARC University – Establish a SAARC university in India, a food bank, and also an energy reserve in Pakistan.